Got Spirit

By Judy Budnitz

Cheerleading, for the true believer, is no extracurricular activity. It is a vocation, a calling. I myself received the call when I was a mere novice, a member of the junior varsity drill team. It was the first football game of the season, third quarter. The score was tied and the tension mounting. Our boys were looking haggard. The spectators murmured softly in their seats. Someone in the stands tossed a cigarette onto the field and it sparked the dry grass on the sidelines. I watched the blaze, and that was when the vision came to me. I stared into those flames, and I heard a voice. It sounded like the voice of the announcer who called the plays over the loudspeakers, but I *swear* to you it was not. It was the voice of the Spirit. School Spirit. It called my name. It told me to take up the pompoms and megaphone and bring my

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message to the people. I was filled with ecstasy. The manager's assistant doused the fire with Gatorade and the game continued. But I knew what I had to do.

INTRODUCTION

Can you remember what your school years were like? In grade school it was all about reading time, coloring sheets, and recess. It was also about tests, report cards, and PTA meetings. As I got older school still involved tests, and report cards but it also involved school spirit and relationships. In the end, that is what makes going to school so exciting. It is friendships, and the bonds that develop over the years. It is having teachers that pour their hearts out into students, day after day. But some people have a different take on school spirit. For all you cheerleaders out there, pardon the stereotypes, but seriously sometimes the mentality gives you guys a bad rap, and who am I to stop the insanity?? Dedicated to the girls everyone loves to hate . . . I've got spirit, Yes I do, I've got spirit how about . . . . Got Spirit by Judy Budnitz

I immediately turned in my drill team uniform and tried out for the varsity cheerleading squad. My ascension was swift. I acquired the short skirts, the tight sweaters. I visited a tanning salon three days a

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week, I had my teeth bleached. I began at the bottom of the ranks but progressed quickly. Soon I was elevated to the second, and then the third tier of the pyramid formations. I learned the jumps, the cheers, the ritual of the pep rally.

During that first season, I came to know the thrill of leading the masses. We regularly incited a stadium full of fans to madness and hysteria. "Let's go, Westside, let's go!" we would chant, and they would repeat the mantra in one voice. I experienced the euphoria of victory, felt my heart catch at the sight of the blazing scoreboard; and I knew, too, the despair of defeat

I gracefully accepted my new social responsibilities. I confined myself to dating varsity players with scholarship prospects. I bonded with my sisters. We had our own table in the school cafeteria. We held bathroom conferences, skipped class to watch soap operas, waxed one another's legs,

We spent our summers at cheerleading camp,

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practicing back handsprings, whip-backs, and slingshots (in both tucked and pike position). During our quieter moments we composed new cheers, heartfelt little haikus full of tender sentiments, which we would later screech at the tops of our lungs to the enthusiastic masses.

Those were the heady, early days of my cheerleading career. I felt invincible. My life had purpose and meaning. My skin was clear.

We practiced two hours a day, followed by an hour of step aerobics or the *Buns of Steel* video. Our stunts were flawless. Our united voices could set off car alarms. I could feel the great Spirit walking among us.

Then came the fall.

Things started to unravel in September. Right at the start of the new football season we lost three cheerleaders in a stunt gone bad. None of us knew what really went wrong. No one on the squad is a genius at physics. Suffice it to say that at the first game of the

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season, we were doing a three-level "Eiffel Tower" human pyramid and there was a weakness somewhere in the structure. No one pointed fingers, but we all had our suspicions. I myself thought Staci looked a bit wiggy that day. School spirit was no match for the forces of gravity. The pyramid fell, bodies tumbled and rolled; several uniforms were irreparably damaged. We lost Bibi and Gwennie and Cat that night.

It was a tragedy, certainly, but we couldn't afford to linger over it; we had to think about the future. We did not want to lose our momentum. We needed replacements immediately. We were forced to hold emergency tryouts. Plenty of eager hopefuls showed up, but our standards were very exacting, and we feared none of the girls would measure up.

Sadly, we were right.

One of the girls who tried out was a member the U.S. national gymnastics team. Corrie could do a great tumbling routine, of course, but her problem was that she just wasn't *happy* enough. She was a solemn girl with big

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circles under her eyes. When she performed the classic cheer "I've got spirit, yes I do, I've got spirit, how 'bout you?' none of us felt for a second that she *really* had spirit.

We'd all seen Corrie on television during the Olympics, sobbing because she won the silver medal instead of the gold. This was a double liability. First of all, we didn't want anyone on the squad who would *cry* on national TV; didn't she have any *dignity?* we asked one another. Second of all, there was the matter of that silver medal. Why not the gold? She'd really let down her team. Let down the whole country. We didn't want a loser like that on *our* squad. For God's sake.

Corrie looked terrified all during the tryouts, and she recited the cheers in a squeaky, strangled voice, as if her gymnastics coaches had snipped her vocal cords to make her neck a little more flexible. And her body was wrong. She was definitely thin enough, but she had no chest at all. You need something there, it's what people like to see. A little jiggle. You can't hold their attention otherwise.

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When Bunny and I tried to explain these shortcomings to her, Corrie started to cry more of those big Olympic-sized tears and said that she couldn't help it. We told her she should have considered implants; lots of girls do it before tryouts. There's no shame in it. As long as you don't tell anyone. If word does get out, your social life is finished. We told her we were sorry.

We had high hopes for another prospect. Her name was Mei-Ii and she almost passed muster. Nice legs, great smile, good straight teeth. Excellent posture. She seemed to have the spirit in her. We were preparing to take her when it came to our attention that she was *not a natural blonde*. When confronted, Mei-li tried to defend herself by saying she was Korean. That's no excuse, we told her. There are rules.

It was unfortunate; we would have accepted her if we hadn't noticed the telltale dark roots. Even then, some of us were willing to let it slide, but Bunny declared Mel-li unacceptable. No bottle-blondes, that was the rule. Bunny was a real stickler; it could cause difficulties at times, but

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we all had to admire her fervor.

We were very excited about a third applicant, LaShonda. LaShonda had *style*. She had the moves. She had grace and panache. She looked fantastic in the uniform. She was unexpectedly strong; we were eager to use her as the base of our human pyramids. She said she was dating a twenty-six-year-old, which pleased us; it meant we wouldn't have to worry about her stealing our boyfriends. You can imagine our disappointment, then, when we discovered that LaShonda was really Sean, and had until recently been the star kicker on the football team. We questioned LaShonda, who burst into tears and swore she was on a waiting list for an operation. We hugged her, some of us cried, too, but we had to tell her no.

"Oh my God, my life is over," LaShonda told us, sobbing into her hands. But Bunny was firm. We had standards to uphold, after all. If we started making compromises, exceptions, then *everything* would fall apart. Without rules, society would quickly disintegrate and soon we'd all be living in the wilderness, eating rats and beetles,

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peeing on the ground and wearing stripes with plaids. At least this was Bunny's reasoning, and it seemed sound to the rest of us.

So when we learned of LaShonda's suicide a short time later, none of us felt particularly responsible. Some of us rationalized it as a sacrifice of the one for the sake of many. I admit I felt a bit sad at the time, and considered dedicating a cheer to her at the next game, but I had so much on my mind that I forgot all about it.

We eventually accepted three girls who managed to meet all our qualifications. Nikki, Sherri, and Tonya were thrilled. big game.

We thought our troubles were over. We hoped the Spirit would return, now that our squad was complete.

During this time, too, Bunny began her campaign to change the school's mascot. She had chosen the phoenix as our new symbol and filled the school hallways with banners and posters depicting the mythic bird. Her reasons were vague; everyone assumed she was simply caught up in the thrill of the winning season.

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The local television stations began broadcasting our games; Bunny smiled fiercely for the cameras, light glaring off her teeth.

I sensed I was being excluded from something; my sisters whispered behind my back. I tried to attribute my uneasiness to the season: It was late autumn, cool and crisp, the dusk began at four o'clock and seemed to last for hours, a mysterious time with the trees like black silhouettes in the dying light; then a purple sky, a prickle of stars, and the voluptuous sighing of mourning doves.

Homecoming approached. The evening before the Homecoming game we held the annual bonfire on the playing field behind the school. The football team set up a huge pyre of old railroad ties and newspapers, then lit it.

It was twilight, that electric, dusky time. Darkness crept around the edges of the field as the flames shot upward. Nearly all of the students and teachers were there. They stood with dazed looks on

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their faces, hushed and awed by the blaze. The band blared out the school anthem, repeating the chorus over and over. My sisters and I turned cartwheels, and I was filled with hope and serenity. All those people, united in a common purpose. And they were watching me. I felt the old thrill. I had veered away from the others. I turned another cartwheel, then another cartwheel, and another, and then I stopped and faced the fire.

I heard a piercing noise and spun around to look. It was the squad.

The cheerleaders. My sister cheerleaders. They were cheering. *Without* me. They were dousing themselves in gasoline, marching into the fire in their flammable polyester uniforms. They were screaming for the Westside Phoenixes, ghastly smiles on their faces as their hairspray ignited; they lifted their arms in final salutes, windmills, Russians, whip-kicks. "We got spirit!" I heard, and "Victory tonight!" and "Let's go, Westside!" And then they were gone.

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Afterward everyone asked me why I didn't join them. The truth is that I hadn't heard the call. Maybe I wasn't ready yet. But most people wouldn't understand that, so I just told them I'd pulled a tendon doing that last cartwheel, and I couldn't make it to the fire in time.

The team won the Homecoming game and went on to win the state championship. At first I tried to lead cheers at the games, alone, but somehow it just didn't feel right.

Westside never did officially change its mascot as Bunny had wanted. We kept the same mascot we've always had. The lemming.

I got back together with my boyfriend. "I hope you're not going to get fat now that you're not doing the cheerleading," he said. But he seems happy enough to have me. After all, I'm the only pretty girl left in the school.

Also I've been spending a lot of time talking to my dad. He's been encouraging me to apply to colleges.

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I think this is mainly because he wants to get me out of the house as soon as possible. I seem to make him nervous, for some reason.

"There are plenty of colleges out there for a girl like you," he told me. "Take your pick."

I said, "I'm glad the other girls are gone; now I won't have to compete with them for the best collegiate cheerleading programs."

My dad patted my knee. He laughed, and then he shook his head and said, "Sweetie, you are living proof that ruthlessness and stupidity are not mutually exclusive."

I'm not sure what he meant by that. But I have ways of making him tell me.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Judy Budnitz
Book: Flying Leap
ISBN: 978-0312198848
Publisher: Picador USA
Date (Month/Year): November 1998

AWARD HISTORY

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KS State Qualifier

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